day now, the model code of conduct will limit his policy space for three months.

But for now, Saini may just need to be himself—and symbolically represent what he does. Khattar, an unmarried RSS pracharak from an urban Punjabi Khatri family, never exuded the vibes of the organically farmed Haryana politician. Unlike him, Saini belongs to a native, agrarian, non-Jat OBC community. There's strong strategic continuity here: His job is to consolidate the rainbow of non-Jats created by Khattar—a vital collage of castes. In both the Lok Sabha and assembly polls of 2019, 70 per cent of the non-Jats had voted BJP.

Vital also because the Jats—Haryana's dominant agrarian community, numbering about 27 per cent of the populace and key to a whole swathe of seats—have for years often inhabited a zone of sullen alienation, extending to anger, vis-à-vis the BJP. The sense of distance from power began when Khattar was chosen in 2014—after a decade of the Congress's Jat patriarch Bhupinder Singh Hooda as CM—despite overwhelming Jat support for Modi in 2014. Things never really reached an even keel thereafter. Instead, the past decade saw a series of aggravating events: the violent 2016 Jat quota agitation, the waves of farmer protests, the wrestlers' protest in Delhi that saw organic khap support for female Jat sportspersons from Haryana on what was perceived, and propagated, as a matter of community honour. Despite his innovative crop pricing policies that benefited all and gave Haryana a robust 8.1 per cent agricultural growth in FY24, the recent tinderbox situation with Punjab's protesting farm unions could have deepened Jat alienation across the entire Green Revolution cluster of states.

In Haryana, that creates a strong chance of a Jat drift towards the rival Congress, which had ignominiously drawn a blank in the 2019 LS polls before recovering to snatch 31 assembly seats and deny the BJP an outright majority. For one, the party boasts powerful Jat figures. Former CM Hooda and his son Deepender Singh Hooda form an axis that always threatens to regain its potency—and they hold down the core Deswali belt around Rohtak, seen as the state's heartland. Lending a stronger air of consolidation to proceedings was another event: on March 10, the BJP's Hisar MP Brijendra Singh, a Jat scion like Deepender, quit the saffron party citing "compelling political reasons" and joined the Congress. In fact, that was the proximate trigger for the BJP's dramatic change of guard. For, what Brijendra's move presages for the Grand Old Party is an even bigger catch: the possible return of his father, former Union minister Chaudhary Birender Singh. His crossover to the BJP in 2014 was seen as emblematic of Jat support then; a return journey would naturally connote the opposite. Birender has been speaking out since the 2020 farmers' protests, and continues in that vein. Addressing the media in his old base of Uchana, Jind district, on March 12, he downplayed the chances of Saini's arrival having much impact and said: "I have advised the BJP leadership about the political line in Haryana, that the way you are trying to connect with the people is not right."

At the tactical heart of the BJP's move, hence, are three objectives. One, shed the Khattar baggage and deflect any anti-incumbency sentiment he may have accumulated; and two, corral together non-Jat votes in a counter-mobilisation. The third delivery, the JJP's ouster, is a googly that may backfire. The Hoodas, from the line of freedom fighter and Constituent Assembly member Ranbir Singh Hooda, and Birender-Brijendra, of Sir Chhotu Ram's lineage, perhaps the most illustrious among Jats, represent two big gharanas in Haryana's polity. Dushyant, great grandson of former deputy PM Devi Lal, belongs to a third—the Chautalas. The BJP hopes that, freed from association with it, he soaks up a spot of sympathy for being wronged, regains his old captive vote, and heads off the Jat drift towards the Congress. Even a tiny deflection of the ball can be key, but the pitch is dicey. For it could boomerang too—the Jats could decisively move to the Congress.

So Khattar bows out, but will now contest from Karnal Lok Sabha seat and perchance move on to bigger things, like a central ministry. Unknown beyond the circle of apparatchiks back in 2014, he was then seen as the prototype PM Modi preferred—fresh, faceless and not enmeshed in existing power matrices. Saini fits that bill too. But rookies can castle as well as rooks on the Indian political chessboard. ■

WHY THE CHANGE



- Nayab Singh Saini, as a non-Jat OBC face, can help the BJP shed some of the baggage Khattar has accumulated
- The plan is to consolidate the entire non-Jat rainbow Khattar had created. Some 70 per cent of non-Jats had voted BJP in both the LS and assembly polls in 2019. A repeat of that would be key
- At the same time, Jats form 27 per cent of the vote and are vital across a whole belt in Haryana–their influence runs to western UP, Rajasthan
- In the recent faceoff with Punjab's farmers, Khattar's warzone-like approach had drawn flak. Ousting him may help placate Jat farming class
- The BJP breaking off from Dushyant may backfire if the Jat votes consolidate around the Congress